

Market: Renewing a simple pleasure

From all the signs, it looks as if the renovation of Faneuil Hall Markets is going to be one of those rare events on today's urban scene, an honest and unpretentious success.

What's happening to this triple row of handsome old brick and granite warehouses is easily one of the best ideas ever to come out of Boston's renewal effort.

The architect for the job is Benjamin Thompson, the developer James Rouse. With a conspicuous lack of Utopian vision of self-importance, what they propose is simply to up the old buildings back to work in the life of the city.

That means not tearing them down in favor of something more "up-to-date." And it equally means not "restoring" them any further to some imagined historical past. Instead, it means recycling them into the contemporary world, with respect—not only for their physical charms but also for the vitality and life they once housed.

Thompson and Rouse propose to do this by pre-

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serving not so much the buildings as buildings but rather the marketplace as a marketplace. Instead of trying to "upgrade" the uses of the building, they instead are putting forward an idea both radical and obvious: to hang onto all those messy, salty, smelly, vitally alive meat, fish, cheese and poultry stalls that fill the area today, and to add to them by attracting many more stalls and shops — shops that will be small and varied, not supermarkets or department stores — so as to recreate once again a real market atmosphere.

Thompson believes that markets provide something that cities need, something the automobile has destroyed. "People need the variety, the abundance that markets bring," he says. "Socially, they need the communal security of personal contact and mutual exchange. Psychologically, they hunger for the festive activity and action that markets add to the central city."

Not only the ground floors, but also the basement and second floor

areas are planned for shops. And more shops and restaurants will spill out of the buildings into the streets — now traffic-free — in the form of glass pavilion, tents and kiosks.

The need to bring life to the streets is a serious one. Thompson points to old photographs of the area as it looked when it was most alive, the foreground invariably jumbled with a rich tangle of street activity, much of it vehicular. — carts, horses, carriages. You can't use vehicles to create street life today, he points out — the cars would kill all the pedestrians. Yet you can't just ban them, or you end up with a desert like Government Center Plaza. So the indoor activities have to move out and into the carefree streets to fill the gap.

Climaxing the whole complex, as it always has, will be the big dome on top of Quincy Market, transformed into a dramatic three-story restaurant.

Just as important as attracting the right kind of activity is driving away the wrong. This has meant manning the dikes against the flood of fraudulent Ye Olde Shoppes that have engulfed so many historic American settings; the kind of place where bored college students, looking silly in 18 Century wigs, peddle copper pots and inaccurate history to a public looking for cheap nostalgia; the kind of stage-set recreations, like Sturbridge or Williamsburg, that historian Walter Muir

Whitehill calls "little paradises of nostalgia in an ocean of super-highways." Rightly, Thompson believes that such activities provide a link not so much with the past as with the media hucksterism of our own time.

Faneuil Hall Markets, in other words is really trying to miss the pitfalls. Nothing points this up better than the rumored earlier proposal, by another developer, to restore the exteriors of the buildings faithfully and then rent most of the interior to, respectively, the telephone company and a dating bar called Your Father's Moustache.

That's a kind of preservation, too, but it's preserving the bathwater, not the baby, the dead husk instead of the life within.

Good as this project is, it got into serious trouble in recent weeks. A sudden controversy erupted over, of all things, the size of the window panes. Traditionalists attacked the scheme on the grounds that the market buildings should keep as close as possible to their original appearance, and that meant lots of little panes in the windows. Thompson argued that buildings, like living organisms, should be permitted to evolve over time.

The dispute — which isn't over, although the danger point seems to have passed — has about the same cosmic importance as the battle, in "Gulliver's Travels," between the Big-endians, who open their boiled eggs from the big end, and their hated rivals the Little-endians. Yet like a lot of arguments about architecture it masks deep and valid concerns.

What the Little-paners really seek is the sense of small scale, the human, textured quality that older buildings have, qualities that aren't obvious in, say, the 60-story machine-cut mirror wall of the John Hancock tower. Little

panes symbolize these human qualities. There are other ways of providing them, though, and hopefully Faneuil Markets will possess the actual qualities and won't need the symbols.

More than most, Ben Thompson may be the architect to achieve that, since he has long been known as an advocate of the little things in architecture—furniture, fabrics, graphic design, color, landscaping, materials—rather than design concepts. Good examples of his work can be seen locally on Brattle street in Cambridge, where two prizewinning buildings, the design Research store (part of a chain Thompson founded) and the Harvard School of Education Library, face each other across the street.

Faneuil Hall Market sits at the crossroads between the North End, the waterfront, the business district, and the Government Center. The possibility that it may become, once again, a marketplace and forum for the city is truly encouraging.

Correction: Last week's column erred in attributing to former Mayor Collins and BRA Director Logue the intention of tearing down part of the Faneuil markets area. This proposal predated the Collins administration. Logue in particular was especially active in preserving the markets.

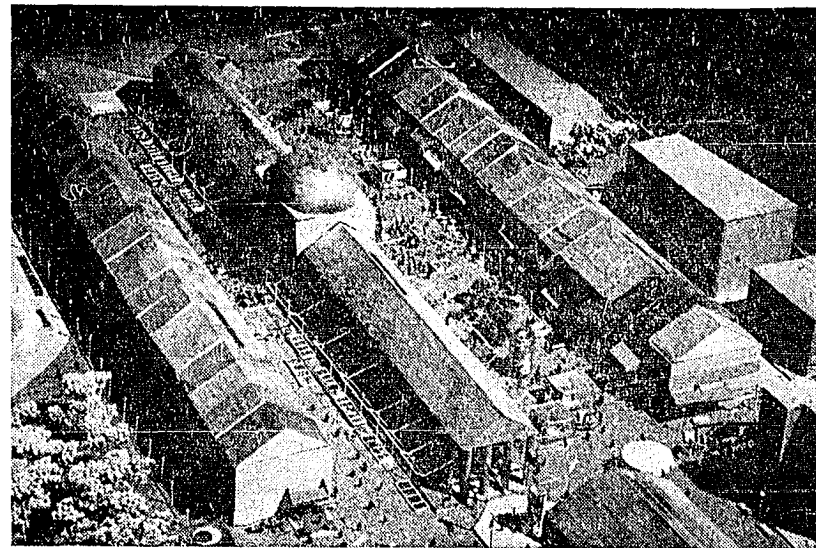


Photo from 1891 (top) shows rich clutter of street life in Faneuil Market area. Marketplace atmosphere will be recreated in current renovation (model below).

